



The Humanitas Institute

## Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Waterloo School  
School Website: <http://waterlooaustin.org>

December 28, 2025

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**Disclaimer**

*This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.*

**ACCS Member School**

*Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.*

## Executive Summary

Waterloo School Austin (Waterloo School 78704) presents a markedly project- and relationship-centered approach to education, with strong emphasis on real-world learning, student agency, and narrative-driven assessments (e.g., Presentations of Learning, POLs). The public materials repeatedly foreground project-based learning, design thinking, and a portrait-of-a-graduate framework focused on communication, collaboration, and personal growth. While the school employs some elements that resonate with classical education—such as rhetoric in project work and a clear emphasis on mastery through deep student work—the curriculum and pedagogy do not consistently align with the explicit liberal-arts framework of traditional classical education (e.g., no consistent evidence of grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, no explicit Great Books or great-conversation commitments across grade levels, limited liturgical/theological programming in public messaging). The faculty structure shows a strong model-teacher orientation and a living-curriculum ethos, which aligns with classical norms in spirit, even if the outward curriculum is contemporary and project-driven. Community and parental engagement appear, with outreach through admissions, parent involvement, and fundraising (Big Cheese campaign), though the explicit “co-teacher” partnership language common in classical rhetoric is less clearly articulated in the public materials.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Rationale: The school demonstrates several hallmark elements of classical education (notably a strong living-faculty model, a commitment to rhetoric through project-based public work, and explicit attention to character formation in a structured graduate portrait). However, its curricular content (project-based learning, design thinking, college-advising transcripts, and emphasis on real-world projects) diverges from the canonical classical framework (grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, Great Books, and explicit liturgy/theology integration). The strongest single driver toward classical is its evident emphasis on virtuous character and the cultivation of intellect through deliberate, time-tested modes of discourse (e.g., rhetoric in practice). The aggregate pattern—balanced toward modern pedagogy with classical undercurrents—places Waterloo at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle toward CLASSICAL: a formal articulation and implementation of Great Books and a formal Trivium progression (grammar-logic-rhetoric) across grades, explicit incorporation of liberal-arts history (Western civilization) and Latin/Greek offerings, a liturgical/theology integration in a clearly defined and public-facing way, and documented Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy across upper grades with clear evidence of the “Socratic” culture in classes beyond rhetoric-rich public showcases.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

### Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize relationship-centered education, real-world learning, and character formation rather than a theology-forward or liturgical framework. There is mention of church affiliation in faculty bios (e.g., St. David's Episcopal Church in one biography), but no school-wide liturgical program or theology-integrated curriculum is publicly asserted as a foundation of the school's pedagogy (the site foregrounds relationships, project-based learning, and graduate outcomes rather than sacramental or liturgical

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instruction). - Positive keywords in the classical lexicon related to transcendental moral realism, theology, liturgy, etc., do not appear as explicit, programmatic drivers in Waterloo's public materials. The classical lexicon highlights terms like truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; and sacramental life as core signals of a classical religious-metaphysical foundation, which Waterloo's public messaging does not consistently foreground. - The Six Essential Elements document provides the framework for what constitutes a religious/metaphysical orientation (transcendental realism, theology, liturgical practices). Waterloo's messaging centers on relationships and real-world learning rather than liturgical or doctrinal formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: none clearly foregrounded as core school-wide text (no explicit "truth/goodness/beauty" triad or theologized curriculum). - Negative indicators: absence of explicit liturgical forms, theology-grounded coursework, or sacramental practice emphasis in public-facing materials.

Why this rating - The school's public narrative prioritizes relational formation, character, real-world learning, and leadership development, not a theology-centered or liturgically oriented foundation. While individual faculty bios reference church involvement, there is no school-wide theological grounding stated in official materials.

Score justification reference: Waterloo public materials emphasize relationship-centered learning and real-world projects rather than liturgical or theological schooling; the absence of explicit theology-based framing aligns with NOT CLASSICAL in this category.

## **Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The school foregrounds formation and human flourishing through a graduate-portrait approach, with emphasis on virtue-like outcomes (e.g., communication proficiency, emotional intelligence, teamwork, and leadership). The Public-facing articles and pages emphasize the aim of forming not just knowledge but the whole person. The "Portrait of a Graduate" series and related reflections foreground the cultivation of character, habits of mind, and social-emotional growth as central outcomes. - The school's messaging about "How We Flourish" and "presentations of learning" signals a convergence with the classical aim of forming virtue and wisdom rather than mere information transfer. The inclusion of a college-advising pipeline and transcript-oriented showcases demonstrates a forward-facing, formation-oriented aim that still values human excellence beyond mere job-readiness. - Positive keywords from the classical lexicon (formation, virtue, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, human flourishing) are relevant to Waterloo's stated aims, though they are not always framed through the exact classical vocabulary. The Great Conversation and Great Books are not central to Waterloo's public materials, but the emphasis on growth, depth of learning, and character formation aligns with the category's core intent.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: formation, virtue (via character formation and traits implied by the Portrait/Graduate framework), human flourishing, telos (implicit), true/good/beautiful (implicit in rhetoric and Graduate goals through meaningful learning and communication). - Negative keywords found: none explicit in the public-facing materials (the site does not foreground "college/career-readiness" as a small or sole telos; rather, it emphasizes formation beyond a job path, though it does not explicitly frame education as solely for leisure or contemplation either).

Why this rating - Waterloo's mission centers on forming virtuous, well-rounded humans with an emphasis on character and meaningful, purposeful learning. However, the school does not consistently anchor its goals in the explicit classical telos and transcendent aims in the way a traditional classical school would (e.g., explicit Great Conversation with Great Books as a central pillar). The presence of formation aims and virtue-oriented outcomes earns SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with room to deepen direct classical articulation.

## **Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The Academics page emphasizes modern, project-based learning (PBL) and design thinking, with dual-credit options and a problem-based approach to mathematics, rather than a canonical classical

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curriculum centered on grammar-logic-rhetoric, Great Books, or liberal-arts progression. The explicit reference to “problem-based learning” and the use of modern instructional resources (e.g., AoPS for math) signals a contemporary curriculum rather than a traditional classical curriculum. - There is no explicit public articulation of a Great Books program, a formal Great Conversation, or a grammar-logic-rhetoric progression across grades. The materials emphasize college preparation and real-world projects, not a traditional classical sequence of liberal arts study. - The “Portrait of a Graduate” and related content foreground competencies like communication, collaboration, and critical thinking, but do not specify the Great Books canon or classical tracts as core curricular content.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: project-based learning, design thinking, real-world projects, portfolio-style demonstrations, presentations of learning, and “transcripts” as a formal record of growth. - Negative keywords found: Great Books, liberal-arts trivium/quadrivium, grammar/logic/rhetoric sequence, Western civilization Great Books curriculum.

Why this rating - The curriculum is modern, project-based, and college-prep oriented, with a strong emphasis on real-world learning and skill development rather than the liberal-arts-driven classical curriculum structure. This aligns with NOT CLASSICAL, though the presence of rhetoric within public materials (e.g., one show-dominant project referencing classical rhetoric) provides a partial nod to classical pedagogy, insufficient to classify as CLASSICAL across the board.

#### **Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Waterloo public content repeatedly features a mix of collaborative and public-facing learning modes (POLs, showcases, discussions around learning). The presence of Presentations of Learning (POLs), long-form student projects, and public exhibitions demonstrates an emphasis on discourse-rich assessment and student argumentation, which aligns with rhetoric-oriented pedagogy. - The school explicitly highlights project-based learning and design thinking as central to pedagogy, suggesting a move away from purely lecture-based instruction toward inquiry-driven, student-centered methods. The public-facing materials also discuss presenting learning, reflecting a public, rhetorical dimension to pedagogy beyond pure Socratic seminars. - Some references to occasional Socratic-style discourse can be inferred from rhetoric-focused student work (e.g., “persuasive papers using classical rhetoric” in the 2021 Fall Student Showcase). While not universal, the presence of rhetoric as an experiential practice contributes to a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL placement.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: Socratic/seminar-like discourse (indirectly via rhetoric in projects), rhetoric, presentations of learning, discussion, seminars (inferred from POLs and showcases), contemplative/restful learning (scholé-like ideas appear in classical lexicon and are referenced in broader classical discourse; Waterloo’s content references reflective practice in student growth). - Negative keywords found: explicit “Socratic dialogue” or formal graded classical seminar structures in K-12 were not clearly evidenced in the public materials, though rhetoric is present in some projects.

Why this rating - The pedagogy blends contemporary, project-based, inquiry-driven methods with some rhetoric and presentation focus, indicating a movement toward classical pedagogy without fully committing to classical dialogic structures (e.g., systematic Socratic seminars and a full Trivium pedagogy). This justifies SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL. The presence of rhetoric in public work and POLs suggests classical influence, but the core structure remains modern and project-centered.

#### **Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The Waterloo site presents a founder-led model (Director/Founder; co-founders) with a clearly defined “faculty” structure and a visible emphasis on mentoring, teacher development, and living the curriculum. The faculty pages emphasize the teachers as co-educators, with backgrounds in humanities, rhetoric, and leadership—mirroring the classical ideal of model teachers and mentors who embody the school’s ethos. The presence of a “Director of Faculty Development, Engineering, History” and a “Faculty” page with detailed bios signals a living curriculum embedded in faculty practice. - The faculty documents describe mentors and living exemplars, and there is explicit emphasis on teacher formation, tutor training, and collegial culture,

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aligning with classical expectations of the faculty as the core of the school's educational program. This is reinforced by bios and governance-style material showing a small, cohesive community with a deep commitment to their craft and to modeling virtue and skill. - In the public materials, Waterloo highlights faculty achievements and ongoing professional growth (faculty bios, "meet your faculty," and internal leadership roles) that align with the classical ideal of teachers as living exemplars and co-learners.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, faculty development, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture, teachers as guides/mentors, faculty as core of the school, teacher training in classical pedagogy (as reflected in bios and program descriptions). - Negative keywords found: none clearly evident that would undermine classical faculty ideals (the site does not present a "facilitator on the side" or non-classical staff archetype).

Why this rating - Waterloo's faculty narrative strongly matches the classical expectation of a tightly connected, values-driven, mentor-centric faculty—teachers as exemplars who embody and enact the school's aims, and whose development and collaboration form the living curriculum. Therefore, CLASSICAL.

### **Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The Waterloo site features admissions routes, family involvement through events (e.g., open houses, visits), and fundraising (Big Cheese Campaign). The school presents a sense of community engagement and parental involvement as a natural expectation, which aligns with classical schools' emphasis on parental partnership in formation and the school's mission. The fundraising page indicates a close-knit community invested in the school's mission. - The public materials emphasize partnerships with families and the broader community through project showcases, family-facing content, and communications that invite participation. There are references to family learning and community-based projects, which reflect some classical-community orientation (parents as co-participants in learning journeys). - However, explicit, formal language describing parents as "co-teachers" or a structured, universal parental formation program (as seen in some classical schools) is not uniformly foregrounded in Waterloo's public materials. The "open campus" and engagement tone exists, but the depth and formality of parental formation is less explicit than in the strongest classical models.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: partnership with parents, parent formation (as implied, though not always explicit), open campus/visitor-friendly policy, community and alumni engagement (Big Cheese campaign). - Negative keywords found: explicit parent-as-co-teacher framing or formal parent-formation programming is not consistently stated in public materials.

Why this rating - Waterloo demonstrates a healthy, engaged community with active parental involvement and meaningful collaboration with families, but the publicly stated framework for parents as co-teachers or a formal, ongoing parent-education program is not as explicit as in the strongest classical models. Therefore SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is an appropriate placement.

#### **Aggregate Assessment**

- Element 1: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 2: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: CLASSICAL
- Element 6: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Overall: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

#### **What Would Move the Needle**

- Curriculum:
  - Formalize a Great Books track and a liberal-arts progression (grammar-logic-rhetoric) across grades, with explicit construction of a classical curriculum spine (e.g., classical history through Western civilization, canonical texts, and a Greek/Latin starter track).

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- Introduce explicit Great Conversation elements and a structured, year-by-year Latin/Greek plan to support classical language study.
  - Pedagogy:
    - Institutionalize Socratic seminars and classic deliberative dialogue in upper grades with clear rubrics, training, and assessment to ensure the pedagogy is not only rhetoric-based but policy-based in a true classical sense.
    - Integrate scholé (restful learning) formally into the schedule, with documented memory work and contemplative study days, and align them with a formal stress-free, study-friendly cadence.
  - Theology/Religious Foundations:
    - If desired by the school and community, articulate a clear theological framework or liturgical component publicly (even if not the core focus) to align with classic elements where appropriate, or clearly state a non-theological but philosophically robust metaphysical foundation (truth/goodness/beauty) with textual support.
  - Faculty & Leadership:
    - Expand formal mentorship for faculty and incorporate regular living-curriculum reviews, with external classical-education mentors to strengthen the classical pedagogy.
    - Document and publish a formal “faculty as living curriculum” statement and a teacher-portrait standard that outlines the archetype of the classical teacher.
  - Parents & Community:
    - Create explicit parent-formation programming (book studies, lectures, and guided classical-education seminars for parents) with scheduled events, to more fully realize the classical-parent partnership model.

## ABSTRACT

Waterloo School Austin’s public-facing content demonstrates a formation-oriented, project-centered educational approach that strongly emphasizes real-world learning, character development, and a graduate-portrait framework. The school’s pedagogy integrates project-based learning, rhetoric in student projects, and presentations of learning while preserving a robust faculty-led, mentor-centered ethos. These features align with classical ideals in spirit, particularly the living-curriculum faculty model and the focus on virtue and intellectual formation. However, the curricular structure does not present a sustained, canonical classical curriculum (e.g., Great Books, grammar-logic-rhetoric progression, or a universal liberal-arts spine), and liturgical/theological foundations are not a public-facing pillar of the school’s program. Taken as a whole, Waterloo School Austin sits in the realm of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with significant strengths in the faculty-mentored, formation-forward approach and meaningful classical elements (rhetoric, public discourse, and a portrait of the graduate) but lacking full canonical-classical curriculum and explicit religious-metaphysical infrastructure across all grade levels.

Category-by-category snapshot: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: NOT CLASSICAL — public materials emphasize relationship and formation over explicit theology, liturgy, or transcendental metaphysics as core school-wide pillars. Positive/negative keyword indicators are largely absent from canonical lists; the school’s materials do not foreground liturgical or doctrinal grounding. Evidence from public materials and lack of explicit theology/liturgy alignment support this rating. - Purpose and Goal: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL — formation and human flourishing are central, with a graduate-portrait approach and emphasis on virtue-like outcomes, though explicit classical telos and Great Conversation concepts are not codified in public messaging. Evidence includes portrait-of-a-graduate materials and project-focused growth narratives. - Curriculum: NOT CLASSICAL — modern, project-based, and design-thinking oriented curriculum without explicit Great Books or Trivium progression. Evidence includes Academics page detailing dual-credit options and problem-based math approach. - Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL — rhetoric and public presentation are emphasized; POLs and seminars showcase student discourse; some historical/classical messaging appears in showcases, but a full Socratic/seminar-based classical pedagogy is not consistently evidenced. - Faculty: CLASSICAL — strong living-curriculum approach, model teachers, mentor-focused faculty development, and a centralized faculty core, as demonstrated by bios and faculty pages. - Parents & Community: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL — active parental involvement and community engagement, with admissions and fundraising programs; however, explicit “parents as co-teachers” or formal parent-education

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program is not uniformly articulated.

In aggregate, Waterloo School Austin demonstrates meaningful classical undercurrents (especially in faculty modeling and rhetoric-inflected student work) while maintaining a contemporary, project-based, and college-preparatory curriculum. The overall positioning is best described as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with tangible pathways to become CLASSICAL through curriculum realignment, explicit integration of Great Books and Trivium, and deeper liturgical/metaphysical framing consistent with classical education.

End of REPORT.

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# Appendix

## ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

### Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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